

the issue was not rampant. On the other hand, Wipro fired 300 employees found to be moonlighting. “Quantification is very difficult. We don’t even know how bad it was to begin with, but we have reasons to believe the quantum has increased in the WFH and Covid-19 period,” says Ballurkar. But there are some base signals that mark out unusual activity that employers tap. A sudden performance or productivity drop, unusual traffic flow on the employer’s systems, excessive use of licensed products and other company resources, unreported absence from the system for a few hours, and changes in the availability pattern of the employee all tell them something’s up. When the employee is confronted, they mostly confess, adds Ballurkar.

Vijay Sivaram, CEO of IT Staffing - Recruitment & Search at Quess Corp, says he has seen instances where clients ask HR firms to investigate certain employees whose productivity levels have dropped without a particular reason. Ankita Ray, Partner at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas, says organisations sometimes hire third-party firms to check whether additional provident fund (PF) is being generated for these employees just to find out if they are moonlighting, although the practice itself

falls under a grey area in the privacy landscape. But recruiters add that PF may not be the best metric either because moonlighting assignments would mostly come without benefits like PF and insurance. “It is tough to estimate it because there are no PF or compliance records of it, and the person could be working as a consultant freelancer. The only way is to encourage employees to disclose their side gigs,” says Sivaram.

For the employees, the forced shift to remote and flexible work during the pandemic opened up a plethora of opportunities. Far away from their managers’ supervision and with time saved by not commuting to office, they were free to explore these opportunities. The primary driver, of course, is money, experts say. One digital and content marketing manager from IBM, who wishes to remain anonymous, has been moonlighting at night as a full-time content strategist with an Australian travel company for a year now. He took it up for some extra income and recently managed to buy a property in his hometown in Uttar Pradesh. “I had some initial trouble adjusting my sleep hours for about a month. But after that, it’s been smooth,” he says, adding that he plans to continue the gig as long as he can.



AUG 26

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